Middle East Technical University
Department of Electrical and Electronics Engineering

EE201 – Circuit Theory I

Lecture 13: Linearity, Thévenin and Norton Equivalents

M. Mert Ankaralı

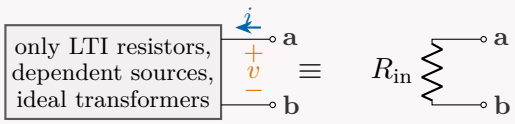
Colour code used in these notes and in the slides			
current i	voltage v, node voltage e	a Δ	a Y

Motivation. Previously, we simplified circuits with equivalent one-ports: series and parallel connections and source transformation. A one-port with dependent sources is not a series–parallel connection of resistors. The first part finds its one equivalent resistor: the **input resistance**. The second part shows that an LTI resistive circuit is **linear** in its independent sources; **superposition** then solves a circuit with several sources one source at a time. The last part adds independent sources inside the one-port: the **Thévenin and Norton** equivalents and the **maximum power transfer** to a load. A take-home part (appendix) gives the **Δ–Y transform** for three resistors that are neither in series nor in parallel.

1. The input resistance of a one-port

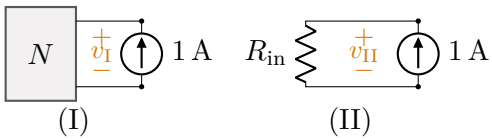
Input resistance

Let a one-port N contain only LTI resistors, LTI dependent sources and ideal transformers, with every control variable inside N. Then N is equivalent to a single LTI resistor R_{in}, the **input resistance** of N: $v = R_{\text{in}}\, i$ at its port.

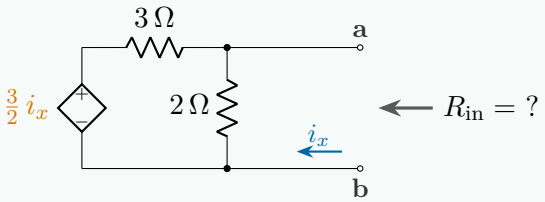


With dependent sources, series and parallel rules are not enough to find R_{in}. A **test source** finds it. Connect a 1 A current source to the port of N (circuit I) and to R_{in} (circuit II). Since $N \equiv R_{\text{in}}$, the port voltages are equal: $v_{\text{I}} = v_{\text{II}} = R_{\text{in}} \cdot 1\,\text{A}$, so

$$R_{\text{in}} = \frac{v_{\text{I}}}{1\,\text{A}}: \quad \text{solve circuit (I).}$$



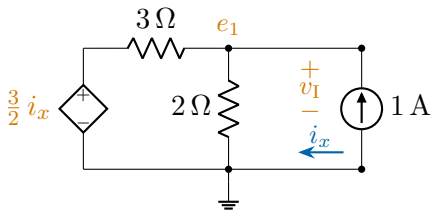
Example 13.1 — an input resistance



The one-port a–b contains a current-controlled voltage source $\frac{3}{2}\, i_x$ and two resistors. Find its input resistance R_{in}.

Solution

Step 1. Connect a test source



Connect a 1 A current source to the port and take b as the ground. Then the port voltage is $v_\mathrm{I} = e_1$ and

$$R_\mathrm{in} = \frac{v_\mathrm{I}}{1\,\mathrm{A}}.$$

Step 2. The control variable first

The test current enters at a and leaves at b, so $i_x = -1\,\mathrm{A}$. The dependent source is then a $\frac{3}{2}\,i_x = -\frac{3}{2}\,\mathrm{V}$ source.

Step 3. KCL at node 1

The current through the 3 Ω resistor, the current through the 2 Ω resistor and the test current:

$$\frac{e_1 - \frac{3}{2}\,i_x}{3} + \frac{e_1}{2} - 1 = 0$$
$$\frac{e_1 + \frac{3}{2}}{3} + \frac{e_1}{2} - 1 = 0$$
$$\frac{5}{6}\,e_1 = \frac{1}{2} \quad \Rightarrow \quad e_1 = \frac{3}{5}\,\mathrm{V}.$$

Step 4. The input resistance

$$R_\mathrm{in} = \frac{e_1}{1\,\mathrm{A}} = \frac{3}{5}\,\Omega.$$

With the dependent source replaced by a short circuit, R_in would be $3 \parallel 2 = \frac{6}{5}\,\Omega$: the dependent source changes the input resistance.

2. Linearity

In an LTI resistive circuit, the independent sources are the **inputs**. Collect the voltages of the independent voltage sources and the currents of the independent current sources in the **input vector** $\mathbf{u} = [\,u_1 \;\cdots\; u_m\,]^T$. An **output** y is any branch voltage or current.

Linearity

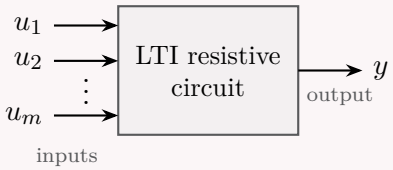
Input u_j alone (the other inputs zero): the output is

$$y_j = k_j\,u_j,$$

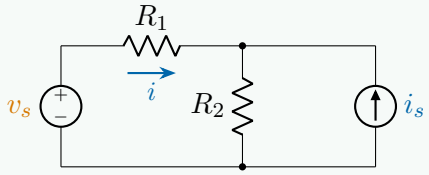
with k_j a constant set by the resistors and the dependent-source gains.
All inputs: the output is the sum of these parts,

$$y = y_1 + y_2 + \cdots + y_m = k_1 u_1 + \cdots + k_m u_m = \mathbf{k}\,\mathbf{u},$$

with the row vector $\mathbf{k} = [\,k_1 \;\cdots\; k_m\,]$.



Example 13.2 — the row vector k



The inputs are $\mathbf{u} = [\, v_s \;\; i_s \,]^T$ and the output is $y = i$. Find k_1 and k_2 such that

$$i = i_1 + i_2, \quad i_1 = k_1 v_s, \quad i_2 = k_2 i_s.$$

Solution

Step 1. KVL around the left mesh

The current source pushes i_s into the top node, so the current down through R_2 is $i + i_s$:

$$-v_s + R_1\, i + R_2\,(i + i_s) = 0.$$

Step 2. Solve for the output

$$(R_1 + R_2)\, i = v_s - R_2\, i_s \quad \Rightarrow \quad i = \underbrace{\frac{1}{R_1 + R_2}\, v_s}_{i_1} \underbrace{- \frac{R_2}{R_1 + R_2}\, i_s}_{i_2}.$$

Step 3. Read off k

$$k_1 = \frac{1}{R_1 + R_2}, \qquad k_2 = -\frac{R_2}{R_1 + R_2}.$$

i_1 is the current with $i_s = 0$, and i_2 is the current with $v_s = 0$ (a current divider).

The implication of linearity

For input vectors $\mathbf{u}$, $\mathbf{w}$ and numbers α, β:

$$y(\alpha\, \mathbf{u} + \beta\, \mathbf{w}) = \alpha\, y(\mathbf{u}) + \beta\, y(\mathbf{w}).$$

3. Superposition

Split the input vector into one source at a time. With two sources,

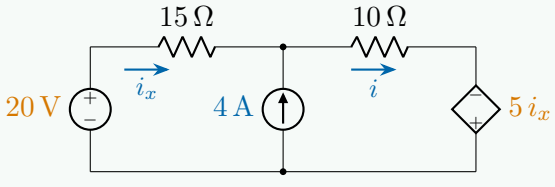
$$y\left(\begin{bmatrix} v_s \\ i_s \end{bmatrix}\right) = y\left(\begin{bmatrix} v_s \\ 0 \end{bmatrix}\right) + y\left(\begin{bmatrix} 0 \\ i_s \end{bmatrix}\right):$$

the output is the sum of the outputs with one independent source at a time. The other sources are **killed**.

Killing a source

Killing an independent voltage source ($v_s = 0$) replaces it with a **short circuit**. Killing an independent current source ($i_s = 0$) replaces it with an **open circuit**. Do **not** kill dependent sources: they are not inputs.

Example 13.3 — superposition



The circuit has two independent sources and a current-controlled voltage source $5\, i_x$. Find i by superposition.

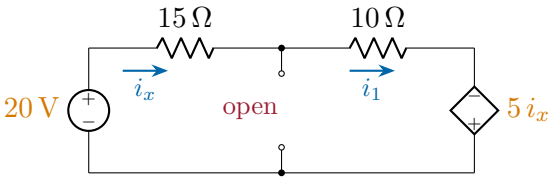
Solution

Step 1. Split the output

$$i = i_1 + i_2,$$

with i_1 from the 20 V source alone and i_2 from the 4 A source alone. The dependent source stays in both circuits.

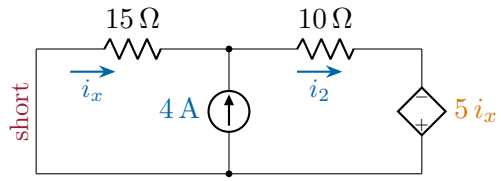
Step 2. Kill the current source (open)



One loop remains, so $i_x = i_1$. KVL:

$$\begin{aligned} -20 + 15\,i_x + 10\,i_1 - 5\,i_x &= 0 \\ 20\,i_1 &= 20 \\ i_1 &= 1\,\text{A}. \end{aligned}$$

Step 3. Kill the voltage source (short)



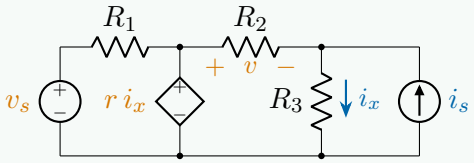
KCL at the middle node: $i_x = i_2 - 4$. KVL around the outer loop:

$$\begin{aligned} 15\,i_x + 10\,i_2 - 5\,i_x &= 0 \\ 10\,(i_2 - 4) + 10\,i_2 &= 0 \\ i_2 &= 2\,\text{A}. \end{aligned}$$

Step 4. Add

$$i = i_1 + i_2 = 1 + 2 = 3\,\text{A}.$$

Example 13.4 — three experiments



	v_s	i_s	v
Exp. 1	12 V	0	v_1
Exp. 2	−6 V	6 A	v_2
Exp. 3	4 V	4 A	v_3

Three experiments are made on the circuit; the element values are not known. Express v_3 in terms of v_1 and v_2.

Solution

Step 1. Linearity

The circuit is LTI resistive, so for some constants k_1, k_2

$$v = k_1\,v_s + k_2\,i_s.$$

Step 2. Write the third input with the first two

$$\begin{bmatrix} 4 \\ 4 \end{bmatrix} = \alpha \begin{bmatrix} 12 \\ 0 \end{bmatrix} + \beta \begin{bmatrix} -6 \\ 6 \end{bmatrix} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \begin{cases} 12\alpha - 6\beta = 4 \\ 6\beta = 4 \end{cases} \quad \Rightarrow \quad \alpha = \beta = \tfrac{2}{3}.$$

Step 3. Use the implication of linearity

$$v_3 = \alpha\,v_1 + \beta\,v_2 = \tfrac{2}{3}\,v_1 + \tfrac{2}{3}\,v_2.$$

No element value is needed.

4. Thévenin and Norton equivalent circuits

With independent sources inside, a one-port is no longer one resistor: it needs one more element, a source. Whatever is connected to the port, a load (a lamp, a motor) or another circuit, then sees only a source and a resistor, found once.

Thévenin's theorem

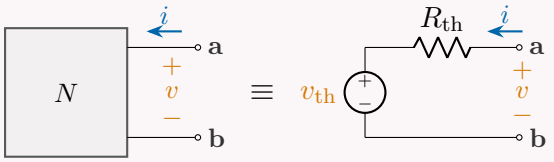
Let N be an LTI resistive one-port, possibly with independent sources, such that

(A1) every dependent source in N has its control variable in N;

(A2) the port is both voltage- and current-controlled.

Then there are v_{th} and R_{th} with N equivalent to the circuit on the right:

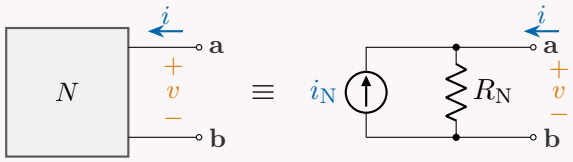
$$v = R_{\text{th}}\, i + v_{\text{th}}.$$



Norton's theorem

Under the same conditions (A1), (A2), there are i_{N} and R_{N} with N equivalent to the circuit on the right:

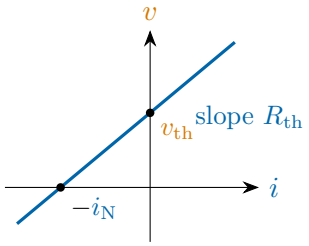
$$v = R_{\text{N}}\, i + R_{\text{N}}\, i_{\text{N}}.$$



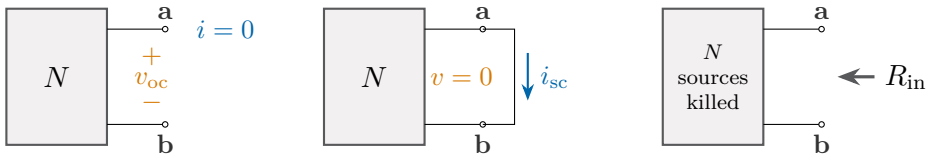
Thévenin and Norton describe the same line. Both characteristics are the same straight line in the i–v plane, so

$$R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{N}} \qquad \text{and} \qquad v_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{th}}\, i_{\text{N}}.$$

Moving between the two is the source transformation (previously). The line meets the v axis at v_{th} and the i axis at $-i_{\text{N}}$; its slope is R_{th}.



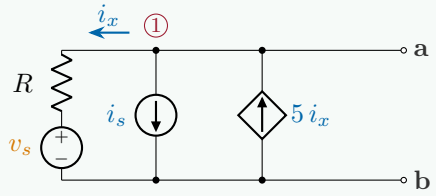
5. Computing v_{th}, i_{N} and R_{th}



1. **Open circuit.** With the port open, $i = 0$ and the Thévenin characteristic gives $v = v_{\text{th}}$: $v_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{oc}}$.
2. **Short circuit.** With the port shorted, $v = 0$, so $i = -i_{\text{N}}$. The current through the short, from a to b, is $i_{\text{sc}} = -i$: $i_{\text{N}} = i_{\text{sc}}$.
3. ***R_{th}*.** Once v_{th} and i_{N} are known, $R_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{th}}/i_{\text{N}} = v_{\text{oc}}/i_{\text{sc}}$. Another way: kill all independent sources in N (voltage source: short, current source: open) and compute the input resistance, $R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{in}}$. Killing the independent sources sets $v_{\text{th}} = 0$ and $i_{\text{N}} = 0$; only R_{th} is left. The second way also works when $v_{\text{oc}} = i_{\text{sc}} = 0$.

6. Examples

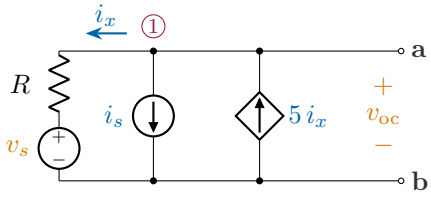
Example 13.5 — Thévenin and Norton equivalents



The one-port a–b contains two independent sources v_s, i_s and a current-controlled current source $5\,i_x$. Find its Thévenin and Norton equivalents.

Solution

Step 1. Open circuit: v_{th}



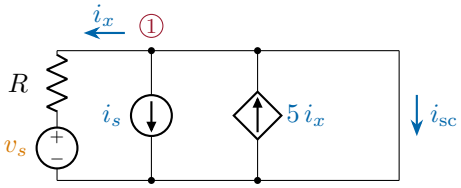
With the port open, $i = 0$. KCL at node 1 (currents leaving):

$$i_x + i_s - 5\,i_x = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_x = \tfrac{1}{4}\,i_s.$$

The node voltage is the drop across R plus v_s:

$$v_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{oc}} = R\,i_x + v_s = \tfrac{R}{4}\,i_s + v_s.$$

Step 2. Short circuit: i_{N}



Node 1 is now at 0 V:

$$R\,i_x + v_s = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_x = -\frac{v_s}{R}.$$

KCL at node 1, with i_{sc} leaving into the short:

$$i_x + i_s - 5\,i_x + i_{\text{sc}} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_{\text{N}} = i_{\text{sc}} = 4\,i_x - i_s = -i_s - \frac{4}{R}\,v_s.$$

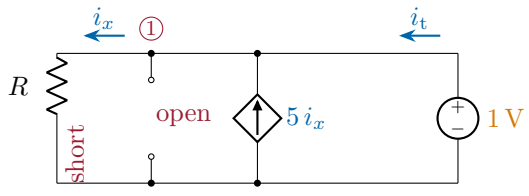
Step 3. R_{th}

The numerator is $\frac{R}{4}$ times the bracket in the denominator:

$$R_{\text{th}} = \frac{v_{\text{th}}}{i_{\text{N}}} = \frac{\frac{R}{4}\left(i_s + \frac{4}{R}\,v_s\right)}{-\left(i_s + \frac{4}{R}\,v_s\right)} = -\frac{R}{4}.$$

It is negative: the dependent source supplies power.

Step 4. Check: kill the sources

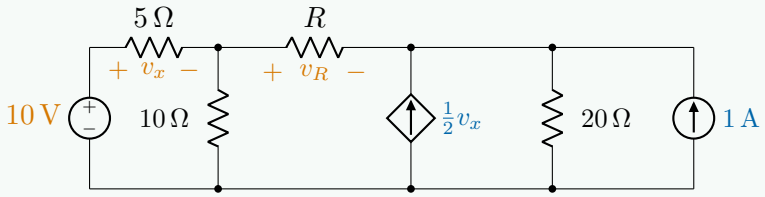


v_s becomes a short, i_s an open; connect a 1 V test source. Node 1 is at 1 V, so $i_x = 1/R$. KCL:

$$i_x - 5\,i_x - i_{\text{t}} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_{\text{t}} = -\frac{4}{R}.$$

So $R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{in}} = 1\,\text{V}/i_{\text{t}} = -R/4$, as before. ✓

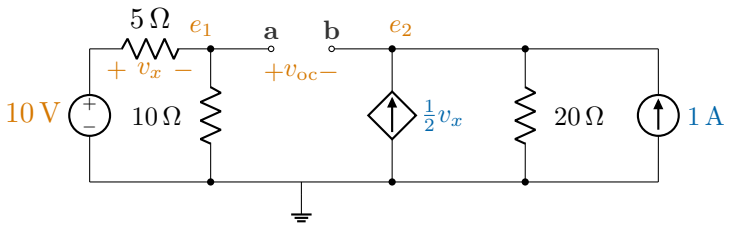
Example 13.6 — a load to design



The load is R. Find the Thévenin equivalent of the rest of the circuit, seen by R. Then find R such that $v_R = -7\,\text{V}$.

Solution

Step 1. Open circuit: remove R



The port a–b is where R was. Take the bottom node as the ground. The two sides are now separate.

Node 1 (left side):

$$\frac{e_1 - 10}{5} + \frac{e_1}{10} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; e_1 = \frac{20}{3}\,\text{V}, \qquad v_x = 10 - e_1 = \frac{10}{3}\,\text{V}.$$

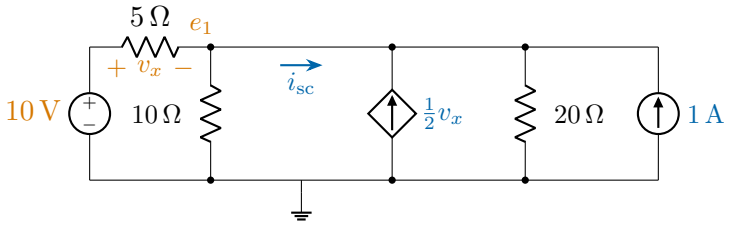
Node 2 (right side), with v_x plugged in:

$$-\tfrac{1}{2}\,v_x + \frac{e_2}{20} - 1 = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \frac{e_2}{20} = \frac{5}{3} + 1 \;\Rightarrow\; e_2 = \frac{160}{3}\,\text{V}.$$

So

$$v_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{oc}} = e_1 - e_2 = -\frac{140}{3}\,\text{V}.$$

Step 2. Short circuit



With a and b shorted, nodes 1 and 2 merge into one node e_1.

Plug $v_x = 10 - e_1$ first, then KCL at the merged node:

$$\frac{e_1 - 10}{5} + \frac{e_1}{10} - \frac{10 - e_1}{2} + \frac{e_1}{20} - 1 = 0$$

$$\tfrac{17}{20}\,e_1 = 8 \quad\Rightarrow\quad e_1 = \frac{160}{17}\,\text{V}.$$

The current through the short, from a to b, follows from KCL on the left side:

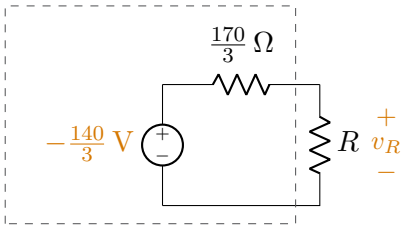
$$\frac{e_1 - 10}{5} + \frac{e_1}{10} + i_{\text{sc}} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_{\text{N}} = i_{\text{sc}} = -\frac{14}{17}\,\text{A}.$$

Step 3. R_{th}

$$R_{\text{th}} = \frac{v_{\text{th}}}{i_{\text{N}}} = \frac{-140/3}{-14/17} = \frac{170}{3}\,\Omega.$$

Check: killing the independent sources (the dependent one stays) also gives $R_{\text{th}} = \frac{10}{3} + \frac{160}{3} = \frac{170}{3}\,\Omega$. ✓

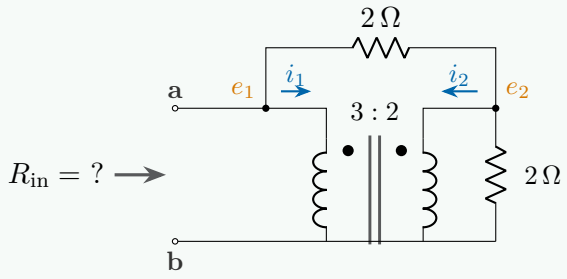
Step 4. Connect R



A voltage divider on the Thévenin equivalent:

$$v_R = \frac{R}{R + \frac{170}{3}}\left(-\frac{140}{3}\right) = -7$$
$$140\,R = 21\,R + 1190$$
$$R = 10\,\Omega.$$

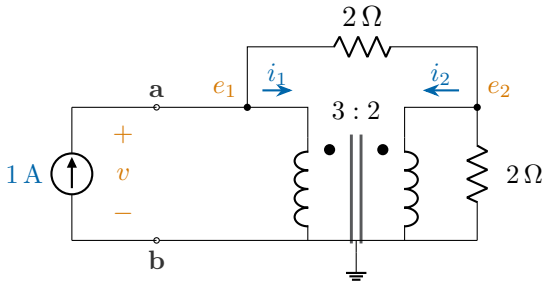
Example 13.7 — an input resistance with an ideal transformer



The one-port a–b contains two $2\,\Omega$ resistors and an ideal transformer $3:2$. Find its input resistance R_{in}.

Solution

Step 1. Connect a test source



There is no independent source inside, so the Thévenin equivalent is R_{in} alone. With a 1 A test source and b as the ground, $v = e_1$ and $R_{\text{in}} = e_1/1\,\text{A}$.

Step 2. The transformer equations first

For the ideal transformer $N_1 : N_2 = 3:2$ (previously):

$$\frac{e_1}{3} = \frac{e_2}{2}, \quad 3\,i_1 + 2\,i_2 = 0 \quad \Rightarrow \quad e_2 = \tfrac{2}{3}\,e_1, \quad i_2 = -\tfrac{3}{2}\,i_1.$$

Step 3. Node equations

$$\text{Node 1:} \quad -1 + i_1 + \frac{e_1 - e_2}{2} = 0$$
$$\text{Node 2:} \quad i_2 + \frac{e_2}{2} + \frac{e_2 - e_1}{2} = 0$$

Step 4. Plug in and solve

Node 2 with $e_2 = \frac{2}{3}\, e_1$ and $i_2 = -\frac{3}{2}\, i_1$:

$$-\tfrac{3}{2}\, i_1 + \tfrac{1}{3}\, e_1 - \tfrac{1}{6}\, e_1 = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; i_1 = \tfrac{1}{9}\, e_1.$$

Node 1:

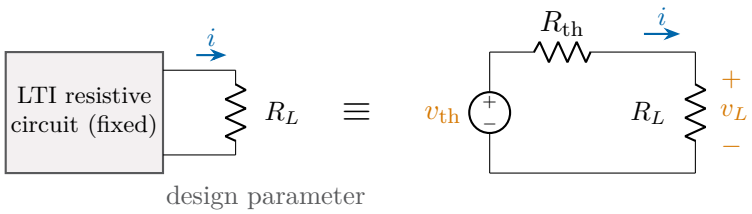
$$-1 + \tfrac{1}{9}\, e_1 + \tfrac{1}{6}\, e_1 = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \tfrac{5}{18}\, e_1 = 1 \;\Rightarrow\; e_1 = \tfrac{18}{5}\,\mathrm{V}.$$

So

$$R_{\text{in}} = \frac{e_1}{1\,\mathrm{A}} = \frac{18}{5}\,\Omega.$$

7. Maximum power transfer

In many applications a fixed circuit should deliver as much power as possible to a load: an amplifier drives a speaker, an antenna feeds a receiver. The circuit is fixed; the load resistance R_L is the design parameter.



7.1. The power delivered to the load

Replace the fixed circuit by its Thévenin equivalent; v_{th} and R_{th} do not depend on R_L. Then

$$i = \frac{v_{\text{th}}}{R_{\text{th}} + R_L}, \qquad P_L = R_L\, i^2 = \frac{R_L\, {v_{\text{th}}}^2}{(R_{\text{th}} + R_L)^2},$$

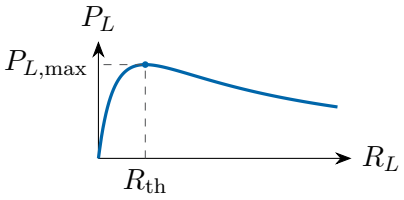
a function of R_L only. Two extremes give no power: $R_L = 0$ is a short circuit, so $v_L = 0$; $R_L \to \infty$ is an open circuit, so $i = 0$. The maximum is in between.

7.2. The maximum

Differentiate with respect to R_L:

$$\frac{dP_L}{dR_L} = {v_{\text{th}}}^2\, \frac{(R_{\text{th}} + R_L) - 2R_L}{(R_{\text{th}} + R_L)^3} = {v_{\text{th}}}^2\, \frac{R_{\text{th}} - R_L}{(R_{\text{th}} + R_L)^3}.$$

The derivative is positive for $R_L < R_{\text{th}}$ and negative for $R_L > R_{\text{th}}$, so P_L has its maximum at $R_L = R_{\text{th}}$.



Maximum power transfer

A load R_L receives the maximum power from a circuit when $R_L = R_{\text{th}}$:

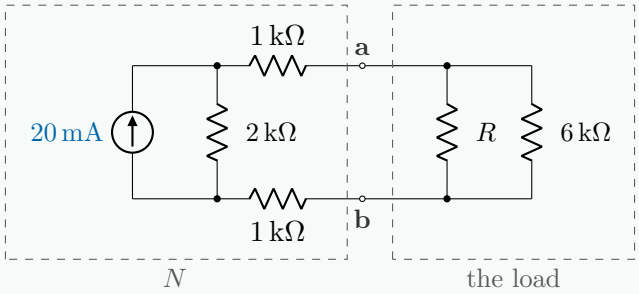
$$P_{L,\max} = \frac{{v_{\text{th}}}^2}{4R_{\text{th}}} = \frac{1}{4}\, R_{\text{N}}\, {i_{\text{N}}}^2.$$

7.3. At maximum power

With $R_L = R_{\text{th}}$, the load voltage is $v_L = \frac{1}{2}\, v_{\text{th}}$ and the current is $i = v_{\text{th}}/(2R_{\text{th}})$. In the Thévenin equivalent the source supplies $v_{\text{th}}\, i = {v_{\text{th}}}^2/(2R_{\text{th}})$: half of it reaches the load and half is dissipated in R_{th}. This statement is about the equivalent; the power dissipated inside the original circuit can be different.

7.4. Two examples

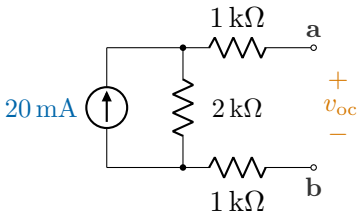
Example 13.8 — maximum power



(a) Find R so that the maximum power is delivered to the load. (b) Find this power.

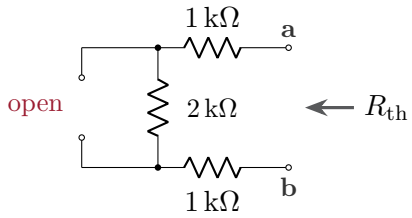
Solution

Step 1. Thévenin equivalent of N



Open circuit. No current flows in the two 1 kΩ resistors, so v_{oc} is the voltage of the 2 kΩ resistor:

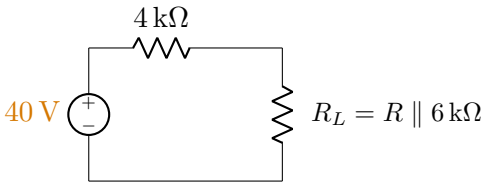
$$v_{th} = v_{oc} = 20\,\text{mA} \times 2\,\text{k}\Omega = 40\,\text{V}.$$



Kill the source (open). The three resistors are in series:

$$R_{th} = 1 + 2 + 1 = 4\,\text{k}\Omega.$$

Step 2. Choose R



The load is $R_L = R \parallel 6\,\text{k}\Omega$. Maximum power needs $R_L = R_{th}$:

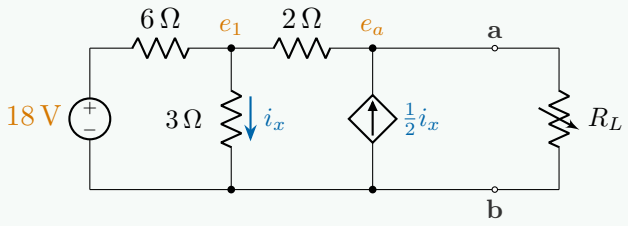
$$\frac{1}{R} + \frac{1}{6} = \frac{1}{4} \;\Rightarrow\; \frac{1}{R} = \frac{1}{12} \;\Rightarrow\; R = 12\,\text{k}\Omega.$$

Step 3. The maximum power

$$P_{L,\max} = \frac{{v_{\text{th}}}^2}{4R_{\text{th}}} = \frac{40^2}{4 \cdot 4000} = 0.1\,\text{W}.$$

The same from the current: $i = 40\,\text{V}/8\,\text{k}\Omega = 5\,\text{mA}$ and $P_L = 4\,\text{k}\Omega \times (5\,\text{mA})^2 = 0.1\,\text{W}$.

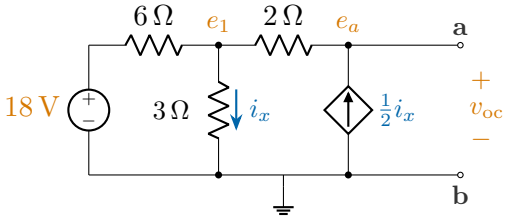
Example 13.9 — Thévenin, Norton and maximum power



Find the Thévenin and Norton equivalents seen by the load R_L. Then find R_L for the maximum power and this power.

Solution

Step 1. Open circuit: v_{th}



Two unknown node voltages, e_1 and e_a. The control variable is the current of the 3 Ω resistor; plug $i_x = e_1/3$ first.

Node a (the dependent source pushes $\frac{1}{2}\,i_x$ into it):

$$\frac{e_a - e_1}{2} - \frac{1}{2} \cdot \frac{e_1}{3} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; e_a = \tfrac{4}{3}\,e_1.$$

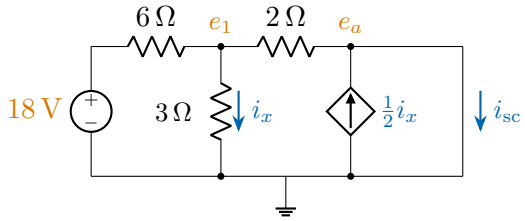
Node 1:

$$\frac{e_1 - 18}{6} + \frac{e_1}{3} + \frac{e_1 - e_a}{2} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; \frac{e_1}{6} - 3 + \frac{e_1}{3} - \frac{e_1}{6} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; e_1 = 9\,\text{V}.$$

So

$$v_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{oc}} = e_a = 12\,\text{V}.$$

Step 2. Short circuit: i_{N}



Now $e_a = 0$, and node 1 is the only unknown.

Node 1:

$$\frac{e_1 - 18}{6} + \frac{e_1}{3} + \frac{e_1}{2} = 0 \;\Rightarrow\; e_1 = 3\,\text{V}, \qquad i_x = 1\,\text{A}.$$

The short carries the current of the 2 Ω resistor and of the dependent source:

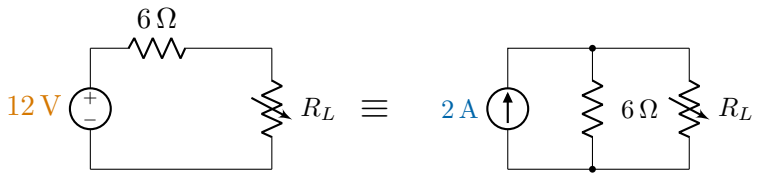
$$i_{\text{N}} = i_{\text{sc}} = \frac{e_1}{2} + \tfrac{1}{2}\,i_x = 1.5 + 0.5 = 2\,\text{A}.$$

Step 3. $R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{N}}$

$$R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{N}} = \frac{v_{\text{th}}}{i_{\text{N}}} = \frac{12}{2} = 6\,\Omega.$$

A 1 A test source with the 18 V source killed gives the same value.

Step 4. The equivalents



Step 5. Maximum power

The load receives the maximum power for $R_L = R_{\text{th}} = 6\,\Omega$:

$$P_{L,\max} = \frac{{v_{\text{th}}}^2}{4R_{\text{th}}} = \frac{12^2}{24} = 6\,\text{W} \qquad \text{or} \qquad P_{L,\max} = \tfrac{1}{4}\,R_{\text{N}}\,{i_{\text{N}}}^2 = \tfrac{1}{4}\cdot 6\cdot 2^2 = 6\,\text{W}.$$

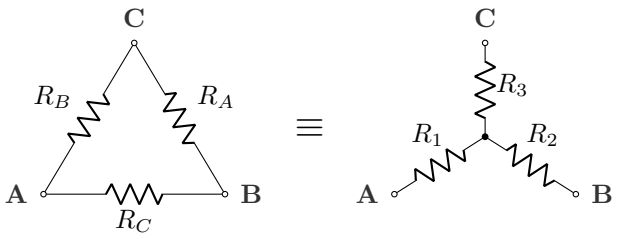
Then $v_L = \frac{1}{2}\,v_{\text{th}} = 6\,\text{V}$ and $i = 1\,\text{A}$.

Summary

In the circuit	What to do
resistors, dependent sources	a 1 A test source: $R_{\text{in}} = v/1\,\text{A}$
a linear circuit	$y = \mathbf{k}\,\mathbf{u}$; $y(\alpha\mathbf{u} + \beta\mathbf{w}) = \alpha\,y(\mathbf{u}) + \beta\,y(\mathbf{w})$
several independent sources	superposition; killed v_s: short, killed i_s: open; dependent sources stay
independent sources inside a load R_L to choose	$v_{\text{th}} = v_{\text{oc}}$, $i_{\text{N}} = i_{\text{sc}}$, $R_{\text{th}} = R_{\text{N}} = v_{\text{oc}}/i_{\text{sc}}$ or R_{in} with the sources killed maximum power for $R_L = R_{\text{th}}$: $P_{L,\max} = {v_{\text{th}}}^2/(4R_{\text{th}})$

A. Take-home: the Δ–Y transform

Three resistors may form a Δ or a Y between three terminals A, B, C. In the Δ, R_A is opposite A (between B and C), R_B is opposite B and R_C is opposite C. In the Y, R_1, R_2, R_3 are at A, B, C.



Δ to Y. Given R_A, R_B, R_C, find R_1, R_2, R_3. If the two are equivalent, the resistance between any two terminals, with the third one open, is the same. Between A and B, the Δ is R_C in parallel with $R_A + R_B$, and the Y is $R_1 + R_2$:

$$\frac{R_C(R_A+R_B)}{R_A+R_B+R_C} = R_1 + R_2 \quad (1), \qquad \frac{R_A(R_B+R_C)}{R_A+R_B+R_C} = R_2 + R_3 \quad (2),$$

$$\frac{R_B(R_C+R_A)}{R_A+R_B+R_C} = R_3 + R_1 \quad (3).$$

Half of the sum of (1), (2) and (3) gives

$$R_1 + R_2 + R_3 = \frac{R_AR_B + R_BR_C + R_CR_A}{R_A+R_B+R_C} \qquad (4),$$

and (4)−(2), (4)−(3), (4)−(1) give the result.

Δ to Y

$$R_1 = \frac{R_BR_C}{R_A+R_B+R_C}, \qquad R_2 = \frac{R_CR_A}{R_A+R_B+R_C}, \qquad R_3 = \frac{R_AR_B}{R_A+R_B+R_C}$$

The Y resistor at a terminal is the product of the two Δ resistors at that terminal, divided by the sum of the Δ resistors.

Y to Δ. Given R_1, R_2, R_3, find R_A, R_B, R_C. From the result above,

$$S = R_1R_2 + R_2R_3 + R_3R_1 = \frac{R_AR_BR_C\,(R_A+R_B+R_C)}{(R_A+R_B+R_C)^2} = \frac{R_AR_BR_C}{R_A+R_B+R_C},$$

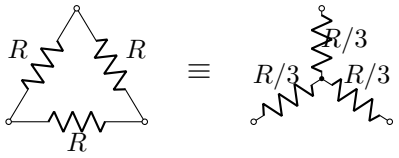
$$R_AR_1 = R_BR_2 = R_CR_3 = \frac{R_AR_BR_C}{R_A+R_B+R_C} = S.$$

Y to Δ

$$R_A = \frac{S}{R_1}, \qquad R_B = \frac{S}{R_2}, \qquad R_C = \frac{S}{R_3}, \qquad S = R_1R_2 + R_2R_3 + R_3R_1$$

A Δ resistor is the sum of the products of the Y resistors, divided by the Y resistor opposite to it.

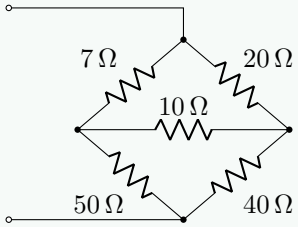
Equal resistors. A Δ of three equal resistors R is equivalent to a Y of three resistors $R \cdot R/(3R) = R/3$. Conversely, a Y of three resistors R is equivalent to a Δ of three resistors $3R$.



Exercise. Write both transforms with conductances, $G_\square = 1/R_\square$. *Answer:* Y to Δ becomes $G_A = G_2G_3/(G_1+G_2+G_3)$, and so on; it has the form of Δ to Y with resistances.

An example: a bridge

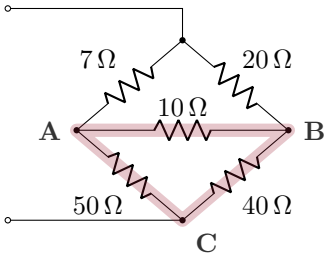
Example 13.10 — a bridge



Find the resistance R between the two terminals. No two resistors are in series or in parallel.

Solution

Step 1. Find a Δ



The 10 Ω, 40 Ω and 50 Ω resistors form a Δ between A, B and C. With the labels of the Δ (each resistor named after the opposite terminal):

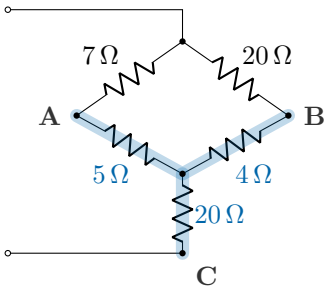
$$R_C = 10\,\Omega, \quad R_A = 40\,\Omega, \quad R_B = 50\,\Omega,$$

and $R_A + R_B + R_C = 100\,\Omega$.

Step 2. Δ to Y

$$R_1 = \frac{R_B R_C}{100} = \frac{50 \cdot 10}{100} = 5\,\Omega, \quad R_2 = \frac{R_C R_A}{100} = 4\,\Omega, \quad R_3 = \frac{R_A R_B}{100} = 20\,\Omega.$$

Step 3. Series and parallel



The left branch is $7 + 5 = 12\,\Omega$, the right branch $20 + 4 = 24\,\Omega$. They are in parallel, and the 20 Ω of the Y is in series with them:

$$R = (12 \parallel 24) + 20 = 8 + 20 = 28\,\Omega.$$

Check: with node voltages, a 1 A test source between the terminals gives a terminal voltage of 28 V. ✓